

NSD, DELHI

NO DRESS REHEARSAL

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AMAL ALANA, CHAIRPERSON, NSD

Enter the small black gates on Bhagwan Das Road, beyond a banyan tree, and one can see a small board bearing the name National School of Drama. It is then one notices clusters of young men in khadi kurtas, a group discussing a script or a play, a quaint bookshop tucked in a corner and notices tacked on a softboard proclaiming theatre in all its forms. Set up in 1959, the National School of Drama (NSD) has been giving the world of theatre its finest protégés since 1961.

As Amal Alana, from the 1968 batch and the current chairperson, recounts her days at the school: “We were a much smaller group of people who wanted to pursue theatre. At that time NSD was at Rabindra Bhavan.” Since then, not only has the institution grown, but also its alumni have walked down many halls of fame. Take a pick. There’s Naseeruddin Shah, Om Puri, Anupam Kher, Ebrahim Alkazi, Sai Paranjpye and Ratan Thiyam. Passing through the portals of the institution remains the privilege of a select few—only 20 students are taken per batch, and taught every nuance of theatre for three years. “Our aim is to create artistes, which is a slow process and requires investment and dedication,” says Alana about NSD’s

intensive course. As Anuradha Kapur, director, puts it, “The moment it started being recognised that art and art education are separate from leisure, we succeeded in giving depth to theatre.” Bharat Rang Mahotsav, a much-awaited annual theatre festival, shows the popularity of the art form. Shows are sold out within hours and ticket rates are as low as Rs 10, making great plays available to everyone, especially young students with an interest in theatre. Their greatest hit is *Ghashiram Kotwal*—the play had a record 116 shows to a packed audience back in 1991.

NSD continues its endeavour in mobilising young people by organising workshops in acting in far flung corners of the country like Sikkim and Mizoram, while also organising extensive programmes for children’s theatre through the famous Sanskaar Rang Toli, the theatre-in-education wing for children from ages eight to 18. In the small rooms of the NSD where scripts and books are turned into reality on stage and sets are created to transport an audience to another era, the aim clearly remains creating a culture where a little drama becomes part of everyone’s everyday lives.

by Bushra Ahmed

RAVI S. SAHANI

